

Barathrum

She opened her eyes. It was not so easy as she had anticipated. Her eyelids seemed to not obey her at all. When she finally got through, she proceeded to try to lift her head. But her head would not budge. The effort, in fact, caused her eyelids to shut tight again; and giving up, she once again let go of herself into a deep oblivion...

There she was again! How long had it been since she had last woken up? Where was she again? *Who* was she again? She tried to think, but the effort strained her brain, which felt as if it was being attacked by fifty hammers at once. So, she stopped, which reduced the pain somewhat. But she did not drown again into oblivion this time; and after a while, which might have a few seconds or which might have been days, she opened her eyes. Voila! Her eyelids responded ungrudgingly this time, and the suddenness of the motion pained them. Her pupils adjusted to the bright light that she was staring straight into. She lingered there for just a few seconds before she shot up. A little bit too suddenly. Her muscles all ached badly and she felt as if her body had been taken apart and reassembled a hundred times. She stood up and looked around herself. A room full of other children. Sleeping peacefully in their beds. Just as she had been, a moment ago.

She tried to walk. What a strange sensation! Her feet did not cooperate with her brain at all. "Obey!", she ordered to them in a hushed voice, in a mildly accented English. Her *voice*! It seemed so alien, as if it was produced by someone else, distant and strange. But obey they did, and she started to walk. A little unsteady at first. She slumped to the ground six times before she made it to the door. Slowly but surely, though, she made progress. Down the dormitory, through the door and into the corridor. It was white everywhere - all the doors that lined the corridor, the walls and the ceiling, even her clothes. It was so silent that she could hear her heart, which seemed to complain and lag in its functioning dangerously.

Then the cold upon the air started to sting into her pale tender skin, biting its way into her insides, diffusing into her body and numbing her throbbing muscles until she lost all sense and control of her body, until she felt as if she was just a head hovering five feet above the ground. Her eyes informed her that her legs continued to walk resolutely down the passage. She was wondering about how her head can feel so heavy, yet be so devoid of any thoughts and emotions, when she put one toenail out of an invisible line on the white, icy-cold, tiled ground. And that's when she heard the deafening alarm go off, the bloodcurdling war-cries rend the air.

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"When do we start?"

"The attacks begin on 22 April, your Highness. The Martians have a huge advantage over us. We may have the most advanced tech and the deadliest weapons, but they can easily defeat us with their sheer numbers. Reports inform us that our total population is not a millionth of their total population. We need to be well armed and prepared."

"Tut tut, Doctor. What are they really, but weak and helpless creatures who have survived all these years, only because of their unusually valuable gifts? They have no intellect of their own.

They have no idea how truly precious their gift is, and how they can do justice to it by utilizing it to its full potential. If they had that sort of intelligence, they would have done it by now. No, those cretinous beings were made to serve. Serve those with higher IQ, surrender themselves and their strange powers to humans, so that we humans can give way to economic progress and development. We aren't fighting them for selfish reasons, Doctor. We are introducing them to the benefits of science and technology. We are actually helping them by sharing with them our standards of living. What did you say was *their* most advanced technology yet? The electric bulb?" His Highness guffawed maniacally.

"Your Highness! Let us not make the mistake of underestimating our enemies again. As it is, we are taking a really big gamble, waging this war. Just look at our numbers! Another thousand of us dead, and our species will be extinct."

His Highness' face immediately assumed an expression of extreme terror, as if he suddenly recalled an unpleasant memory from his past. When the moment passed, he said in a gentler tone, "Yes, I understand. Prepare for the worst. Unite our forces. Recruit the best among us for this operation. This battle is going to rewrite history. If we win this, then I will go down as the greatest ruler that ever lived in the history of mankind, the saviour of humanity. In the new world, where I will be the ruler, you shall be bestowed with titles and awards and medals and whatnot."

"His Highness has a big heart."

His Highness took a moment to savour the rush of pure joy he experienced at the thought of winning the war, and what it would mean for the future of mankind; and then said, "And what about the secret?"

"Yes, your Highness. Stultus and his secret force are working day and night."

"Good. The secret will lead us to our glorious victory over the Martians."

"Yes, your Highness."

Dr. Agers bowed and his Highness walked away. He waited for the final sounds of his Highness' heavy footsteps to fade off in the distance, before making a beeline for his laboratory. He made a couple of urgent phone calls, and was anxiously studying some sort of a map, his brows knitted, when a small LED marked 'Emergency' on the panel of buttons and switches in front of him started beeping furiously, and a screen in front of him showed 'Breakout in Dorm 341'. He smiled and banged his fist on a big red button marked 'Kill'.

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The heat of the moment brought her and her body back to the present. She stopped her feet so abruptly, that she swayed and fell down, flat on her face. The ground under her was quaking and she could hear the war-cries approaching, when suddenly every single door that lined the corridor opened in unison, and from inside each one of them poured out streams and streams of children, all dressed in that same bright white as herself. They marched out in an eerie synchronism that produced a booming sound that far overpowered the screeching alarm, and

caused the whole building to tremble; and she decided that they were not humans – they were robots.

As she turned around on the ground, she saw three of them pouncing on her, their bodies soaring through the air in perfect unison too. Her hand shot up in air, her fingers curled into a fist, and her knuckles jammed into the nose of one of them before she knew what she was doing. “CRACK!” She watched horrified, as a strong gush of hot blood burst out from his nose, splattering all over her face and on the snow-white ground. The hot blood felt stinging on her freezing face, and she gulped down a lot of bloody saliva. The worst bit was that he did not even as much as flinch, rather his fingers curled smoothly around her neck and his thumb pressed firmly against her throat, while blood flowed freely down his broken nose, staining his disfigured face.

The other two landed clean on her right shoulder and left thigh respectively, and she heard a loud crack she could not determine the source of. As a searing pain spread through her four limbs, she tried to let out a scream, except she seemed to have lost her voice somewhere beneath the first boy’s thumb. Another three stepped out and pounded on her, and she lost all sensation of her body. Her head started going dizzy and the world started going in and out of focus. The face of the boy with the broken nose, that she was staring into, multiplied into twofold, and then fourfold, and then a hundredfold, filling her vision with vibrant kaleidoscopic patterns flooded with red and white.

Then the world went black and completely silent. Endless cold and hatred. Then from the distance approached the figure of a person. As he neared, it became clear that he was holding a gun. He was almost immediately in front of her when from the silence arose a voice. No, not a voice, a scream. That voice stirred something deep inside of her, something that had been locked and stored away, but not lost. A memory. “NOOOOOOOO!” she yelled into the darkness. For just an instant, a dim light from an invisible source fell on the face of the person in front of her. He was not the one screaming. He wore a bloodstained purple mask to hide his face. The only part of his face that was visible was his set of brilliant pearly white teeth, displayed in a wide and malicious grin. But before she could make sense of anything, before she could clearly recognize or recall who that voice belonged to, everything quietened down again; the person in front of her vanished into the blackness. Another pitch-darkness. But this time, it was not cold and unforgiving. It was filled with blissful warmth and happiness, comforting her broken soul, healing every single one of her aching body parts. She almost purred with joy, bathing in endless contentment.

And that’s when she woke up. She was dripping wet in her sweat, her body was shaking uncontrollably, and her forehead seemed as it was on fire. She was lying on the ground, which must have been as hot as the surface of the Sun. *Was she dead? Was this where dead people are taken to? How could she not be dead? She must be.* She first thought that she was all alone, but then she traced her attention along her left hand. First came the shoulder, well and intact, unlike her right shoulder which had been broken by the boy who had jumped onto it. Then her upper arm, and then her elbow. Her dread increased as she furthered along her hand. The lower arm, the wrist and then – she suddenly sat up and looked at it. The boy with the broken nose lay beside her, dead as a doornail, his once handsome face now grotesquely disfigured and

dented because of her punch, stained with his own blood, convulsed but expressionless, the life drained out of his beautiful blue eyes; while her left-hand fingers still wrapped themselves around his throat, digging deep into his skin.

And then she fell down on the sweltering ground.

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His Highness was pacing up and down the room, his hands behind his back, his lean and frail figure bent forwards.

The doctor stood in the corner rigidly, looking down at his feet, and feeling dizzy.

I wonder what's for dinner. I'll ask Martha after His Highness is through with me.

"This is the second time in, what, two weeks?" His Highness asked, softly. The doctor continued looking down, not daring to speak.

Argh! Those shoes haven't been polished in three weeks! I hope His Highness doesn't notice them. Martha is in for it today.

"I am disappointed, Doctor. Highly disappointed." His Highness said, silkily.

Ah! This reminds me. When was the last time, I had my feet pedicured, again? Those toenails need some desperate treatment.

"You understand that we cannot let this continue, don't you?"

Silence.

"Doctor? SPEAK!" His Highness barked, and the doctor shook as if he was splashed in the face with freezing water when he had been asleep.

"Yessir!" The doctor cried.

"Good. And I hope your team is working to remedy this."

"Twenty-four, seven, sir."

"And yet, you understand that we have not the time for twenty-four, seven, Doctor. The attacks are to start on 22nd April, and if you and your team have any real help to offer to the cause, then it must be immediate." His Highness said, coldly.

That comment struck a chord somewhere in the young Doctor's brain. It hit too close to home. This was serious, not a time to fool around, worrying about trivial matters. He finally understood the gravity of the situation. Of course, his Highness was right. His Highness usually always was. He had disappointed him. He had one chance to impress his childhood hero. One chance to contribute to the noble cause that he had been so eager to become a part of always. And he had lost it. He had one job, *one simple job*, and he had failed at it. Terribly. He, the smartest person on the planet, he who had got through, he who had cracked the code at a tender age of twenty-two, that for centuries, even the biggest scientists of Earth had been unable to,

he who had rewritten history and forever changed the scientific landscape for humanity. His head drooped two inches further down, and he maintained his silence.

Even his Highness realized that he had gone too far. His entire scheme couldn't have been possible without the doctor. He knew how dedicated the doctor was to his work.

"Please, Doctor. I highly regard your ingenuity, your absolutely brilliant brain. It has proven to be an invaluable asset at several instances. I have no doubts upon your intents, any more than I have upon my own. I highly value your undying faith in my schemes, and I don't know where I would be today, without your support. We are building a new world, Caecus, and I can't achieve it without you. We mustn't let anything stand in our way. It is just a matter of another three months, and then we will be liberated. Forever." His Highness said.

These kind words of his Highness stung more than the severest possible punishment on Earth. The doctor felt agonizingly guilty and helpless.

"Yessir."

"So, who was it this time?"

Now, the doctor finally looked up. And when he did, you could almost see a hint of admiration in his eyes.

"She's just a fourteen-year-old, sir."

"And has she been eliminated?"

"Yessir. Completely. Turned to vapours, sir."

* * *

She woke up yet again. She was sick of this game. *Now*, where was she? She sat bolt upright and looked around her, irritated and annoyed. She was in a similar bed as that one in which she had been lying in along with the other children. But this time, it wasn't a dormitory. Hers was the only bed in the small room. Her right arm was covered in a hard and thick white layer of plaster, because of which she could not move her arm. Her immobile arm hung lifeless from a sling that looped around her neck.

She tried to recall whatever she could about herself. *Who was she?* She did not know. *Where was she?* She did not know. *Who were those children?* She did not know. *Why did she kill that boy?* She did not know.

She walked to the door and unlocked it. On its other side were three people sitting around a table. The first one was a young and beautiful woman sitting politely on a chair. The second one was an extremely ancient man who sat on a wheelchair and wore glasses that magnified his eyes to many times what must have been their true size. When she turned to look at the last person in the room, her spring green eyes only met his identical spring green eyes for just an instant. Her body reacted faster than her mind could comprehend what happened, and she found herself throwing herself into his outstretched arms. The word parted from her lips with a huge sigh of relief before she knew it, "Chris!"

He responded with equal vigour, “Dahlia!”, speaking in the same, lightly accented English as herself.

The word as if ignited a fire to her brain. A million recollections from her past flooded into it, which seemed as if it would burst under the pressure.

Chris’ grip on her slipped and both of them fell to the ground. Dahlia crouched down, her head between her knees, her hands on top of it. It was too much. She couldn’t handle it. She wanted to go home. She wanted to go home with her brother Chris and never leave him again. *Home? Where was her home? Did she have a home? Did she have a family?* The harder she tried to think about it, the blanker her mind went. All she could think of in this world right now, was Chris.

“Dahlia”, whispered the lady softly. “Have some food.”

She lifted Dahlia into a sitting position and passed her a bowl of something that Dahlia took no notice of. She looked at Chris. He was sitting on the chair across her. One look at his pale and trembling face told her that he had also been through the same as she had. His eyes were bloodshot, and he was sweating profusely even though the room was freezing cold.

She turned to look at the old man, and was startled to find him staring at her intently, a triumphant smile on his lips. The sight of him smiling at her infuriated her, and she suddenly made an attempt to plunge at him, ready to tear him apart with her raw hands. He seemed to have some degree of control in her life, and she did not much like the way her life was going on at the moment. He immediately pressed a button on his wheelchair and thick black belts sprouted out from the edges of her chair and buckled at the middle, securing her firmly in place. She protested fiercely, violently trying to break free, but could do no better than wiggle her waist from side to side. After about five minutes of wildly struggling on the chair, banging her solid right arm on the edge of her chair, she gave up and spat on his face.

The old man just beamed even more warmly and then said in a voice that seemed as ancient as he looked, hoarse and croaky, but sweet and polite nonetheless. “Oh, my dear Dahlia! What a life you have had! Such struggle! At such a tender age too.”

Chris shot him an ugly look and Dahlia spat at him once again. “Who are you? Why are we here?”

“Now, now darling! Dahlia and Chris! Behave. I am here to answer all your questions. Now you must promise me this. I will explain to you everything. Where you are and why you are here and everything. But first, I’ll ask you a few questions. You must promise me to answer those as honestly as you can. Nothing hides between you and me.”

“And why would we do that?” Chris said.

“Because I saved your lives. Both of yours. Do you think you could have made it out of that army of bloodthirsty child-bots, alive? Eh, darling? If I wasn’t there to drive them away, to collect you unscathed in the incinerator. If I hadn’t *turned off* the incinerator in the first place? Of course, it wasn’t built to rescue the escapees. It was meant to *burn* the escapees. The floor splits open along the centre, and both sides withdraw into the walls, dropping you to your

doom. As an extra precaution, if the child-bots can't handle the situation. Of course, we didn't use it for its true purpose once; you two are the only ones who have managed to escape the secret training centre till now. And I heard that Stultus got a good scolding from Hominus, about your escaping." Said Dr. Agers, chuckling.

"Secret what?"

"Now, now Chris. Everything in its due time."

"Wait! Why are children being locked up like this? What's going on? Who are you? Where are we?"

He sighed. "Well, I guess I owe you an explanation first."

He held out his hand to them. "I'm Dr. Maschera Agers, Head Scientist of Barathrum."